

The Road to Aparecida



DH-101 Comic Description (6 Panels)

Panel 1 - The Purpose

A young pilgrim stands in São Paulo with his backpack, looking toward the road ahead.

Caption:

Before I started, I already knew why I was going. My purpose was clear: to strengthen my faith.

The AI appears only as a tool on his phone, helping him trace the route from São Paulo to Aparecida.

Panel 2 - The Challenges

The pilgrim walks along the road while the AI helps him prepare for the journey.

AI:

“Here is your route from São Paulo to Aparecida. I can also warn you about weather, traffic, and possible dangerous areas.”

Caption:

The technology could help me prepare, but I still had to face the road myself.

The panel shows difficulties that a pilgrim may encounter, such as heat, rain, blisters, long distances, exhaustion, and loneliness.

Panel 3 - The Hard Moments

The pilgrim sits beside the road, exhausted after walking for a long time. His shoes are dirty and his body is tired.

Thought bubble:

“Maybe I can’t do this... It’s too far. I’m so tired.”

Caption:

There were moments when I seriously thought about giving up.

Panel 4 - Faith in the Journey

The pilgrim continues walking while holding a rosary. The sun is setting, and the road stretches into the distance.

Caption:

When my body was tired and my mind was full of doubts, I chose to keep going.

Thought:

“I prayed, I reflected, and remembered why I started.”

Panel 5 - The Reward

After days of walking, the pilgrim finally sees the Sanctuary of Our Lady of Aparecida in the distance.

Thought bubble:

"I made it..."

Caption:

After every difficult step, I could finally see the destination.

Panel 6 - The Meaning

The pilgrim kneels inside the Sanctuary before Our Lady of Aparecida.

Caption:

I came to Aparecida with a purpose. I faced the challenges. I found my faith. And I arrived.

Final reflection:

The journey was never just about walking. It was a journey of faith, strength, and gratitude. Every step, every doubt, and every prayer was worth it.

Commentary

In this comic, I wanted to show that my pilgrimage to Aparecida was more than a physical journey. Before I started walking, I already had a purpose: I wanted to strengthen my faith. The destination was important, but the meaning of the journey was even more important to me.

I used AI as a tool during the preparation of the pilgrimage. It could help me trace a route, organize the journey, and identify possible difficulties such as weather, traffic, and dangerous areas. However, AI could not walk the road for me or experience the physical and emotional challenges of being a pilgrim.

The comic shows how the journey became difficult through heat, rain, exhaustion, long distances, loneliness, and doubt. At one point, I even thought about giving up. However, prayer and remembering my original purpose helped me continue.

Using the comic format allowed me to show this transformation visually. The first panels focus on preparation and difficulty, while the final panels move toward faith, perseverance, and arrival. In the end, reaching the Sanctuary was not only reaching a destination. It represented the result of continuing even when the journey became difficult.

This experience showed me that AI can help guide the route, but only I can walk the journey.

Attribution & AI Use

- **AI Tool:** ChatGPT (story development, dialogue, and reflection), image-generation AI (comic illustrations)
- **Human Contribution:** Personal experience and concept, purpose of the pilgrimage, six-panel structure, selection of challenges, editing, and final message
- **AI Role:** Helped organize and visualize my ideas, but the personal meaning and purpose of the pilgrimage came from me.